A structure such as the tomb of Salar Khalil not only exquisitely personifies the many factors contributing to its own process of becoming – that is, its architectural culture – it also demonstrates the impediment that an overdetermined reliance on dynastic labeling can create[55]: rather than facilitating entry into historically germane processes, the quest for a top-down dynastic appellation obscures our apprehension of changes in architectural culture that were incrementally effected, at least to some degree by the dialogue between shifts in patronage and the artisans' responses to them. It was just such a dialogue that the newly ascendant Shansabanis had to master if they were to achieve dominance both within their lands of origin and beyond. And it is this fundamental process that buildings help us to understand, whether among well-heeled Persianized elites grasping for an empire, or politico-cultural novices emerging from the nomad–urban continuum, thrust forward by what were essentially historical accidents such as "better access to … trade routes, good luck … [and] ambitious and skillful rulers."

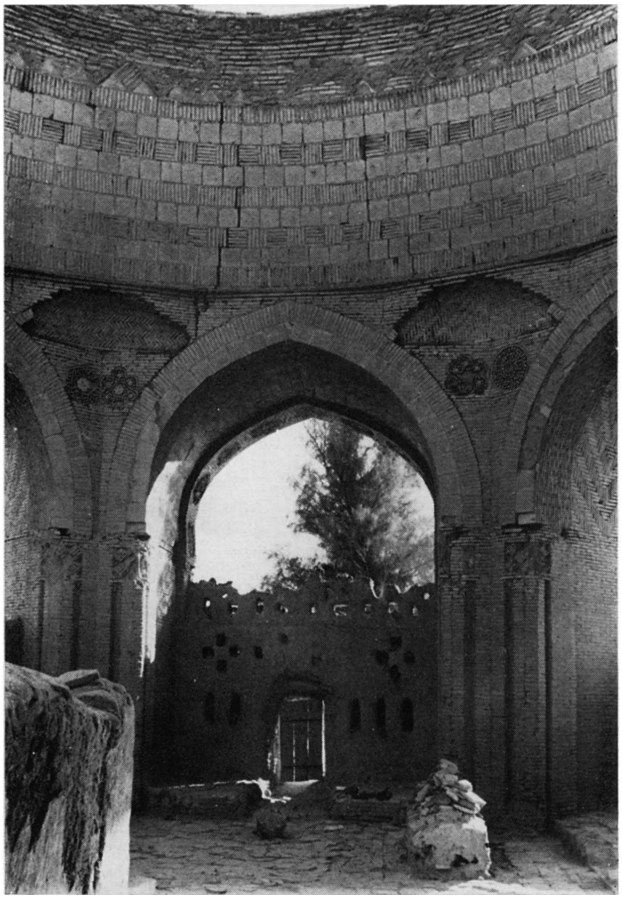


Figure I.19 *Tomb of Shahzada Sheikh Husain, near Bust, interior. From Crane 1979: fig. 8.*

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Before embarking in earnest on this Volume's examination of the emergence of the Shansabanis on the eastern fringes of Khurasan during the mid-twelfth century, and their eastward progress to the Indus's alluvia shortly thereafter, the difficulty of fieldwork in large swaths of Afghanistan – including the central region of Ghur itself – must be acknowledged. Given the inaccessibility of many of the early Shansabanis' core areas of activity, projects such as mine perforce rely on historical and other documentation, which has come from a wide variety of sources.